

- 7.c) The concept of cultural relativism and the ensuing debates surrounding it have sparked discussions within Anthropology. Comment. (15 marks)

Cultural relativism refers to the anthropological approach of studying the customs and ideas of a culture objectively by taking into consideration its circumstances.

Fransz Boas laid the foundation of cultural relativism through his historical approach.

Contextual  
Grndos

Basic  
tenets  
?

### Utility of Cultural Relativism

- 1.) Helps understand human differences as the relativist approach gives an objective framework to study different cultures.
- 2.) Busting various myths such as apex culture or ethnocentric view of evolutionists.
- 3.) In applied anthropology as cultural relativism helps understand the intricacies of culture and the approach needed to frame policies for them. (Paul Rosenblatt)

Valid  
Points

However, the concept of cultural relativism has sparked various debates. because of its approach.



### Types of cultural relativism

- Soft - Takes an objective view on each practice of culture
- Hard - completely justified all practices of a culture

This hard approach has led to debates.

### Cultural relativism and human rights

Human rights refer to the rights accruing to the individual by virtue of human and essential for survival. UN declaration of human rights has laid down various rights.

→ Hard cultural relativism even justifies the abhorrent practices of cultures such as slavery, atrocities on women, killings. - eg) Naga head-hunting

Elizabeth Zechenter in her book "In the name of culture: cultural relativism and human rights" criticizes this approach of cultural relativism as she argues that UNHCR lays down the basic human rights below which any practice should not fall and such practices that do should not be condoned.



Another debate ensuing since centuries is the cultural relativism vs ethnocentrism but it is mostly settled now against ethnocentrism.

As Michael Banton says, cultural relativism should be used only as a tool to approach study of cultures. Objectively

Explain more  
Debate.

→ Cultural vs Ethnocentrism  
Relativism

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Word Limit

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15